

YASBANT NEGI



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OF VOTERS IN TWO-PARTY STATES LIKE MADHYA PRADESH AND RAJASTHAN DIDN'T VOTE FOR THE CONGRESS OR BJP IN 2008.

HEAVYWEIGHT REGIONAL ALLIES ARE QUESTIONING THE CONGRESS POLICY OF PROJECTING MANMOHAN, SONIA AND RAHUL IN THE COMING POLLS

latest edition of NCP mouthpiece *Rashtravadi*. The magazine has called the Congress confidence 'fake' and held Sonia and Rahul responsible for it, though Pawar, diplomatic as ever, was quick to dissociate himself from the view. For certain satraps in UPA, the prime ministership is still an open question. If NDA misses a Vajpayee, UPA needs a stronger Gandhi.

For the Big Two, despite the election-eve bravado, it is a struggle against impending redundancy. They are losing the space, and there are no citadels they can boast of. The most glaring is the absence of truly national leaders who can arrest the decline. No na-

tional party has been able to get an absolute majority since 1989. Most state leaders feel that the combined tally of the national parties will not cross the 272 mark as against 283 they won in 2004. Leaders of the undefined Third Front are confident of winning over 180 seats—which will be more than the present tally of BJP and Congress. BJP hopes to contest only 275 to 300 seats; the Congress target is to contest over 375 seats. The aspiration is not matched by the ability of the leadership, for both parties suffer from the absence of a leader whose appeal is national: the leader as a movement, as a transformational figure. Advani still scores poorly in acceptability quotient. He is not yet Vajpayee as Sonia is not yet Indira. Sonia and Rahul may have succeeded in keeping the party alive and winning new friends, but they have failed in restoring the Congress's historical status as the natural born ruler.

The last Assembly elections in Rajasthan, Madhya Pradesh, Chhattisgarh and Delhi were a revelation. The BJP suddenly realised that a terrorist attack on the nation would not necessarily benefit the so-called nationalist party. The party's disastrous performance in Delhi and its defeat in Rajasthan made its allies wary of BJP. Then it had to cope with the rebellion by Bhairon Singh Shekhawat and Kalyan Singh. Party President Rajnath Singh, in a show of total surrender, gave the management of the organisation as well the elec-

tions to the nominees of Advani. Narendra Modi and Rajnath have been forced to play second fiddle to the Advani-ites in the party. The victory in Rajasthan and Delhi has made the Congress more arrogant. It refuses to learn from BJP's journey from a shining fantasy to a darker reality five years ago. Today, the shine is entirely on the allies, resurgent and ready to set the terms of E-2009. The big question is: will the country be ruled by the states or from New Delhi? A tremulous Centre has already given away the answer.

with Priya Sahgal, Bhavna Vij-Aurora and Shafi Rahman